

Subject Matter Expert (SME) Interview Questionnaire

Purpose: This questionnaire is a reusable template for gathering accurate, complete information from a Subject Matter Expert before drafting technical documentation (user guides, SOPs, work instructions, API documentation, training materials, or process documentation). Adapt the question set to the deliverable —

not every section applies to every project.

Interview Logistics

Field	Details
Interviewee name	
Role / title	
Department / team	
Date of interview	
Interviewer	
Documentation deliverable	e.g., user guide, SOP, API reference

Field	Details
System / product / process being documented	
Follow-up interview needed?	Yes / No

1. Background and Context

- What is this system, product, or process, in your own words?
- Who uses it, and what problem does it solve for them?
- How long has it existed? Has it changed recently, or is a change planned?

- Is there any existing documentation (even outdated or informal) I should review first?
- Who else should I talk to for a complete picture (other SMEs, end users, engineering, compliance)?

2. Audience and Use Case

- Who is the primary reader of this documentation? (skill level, role, technical background)
- What situation brings them to this document – onboarding, troubleshooting, reference lookup?

- What do they already know, and what can't we assume they know?
- Are there multiple audiences with different needs (e.g., admin vs. end user)?

3. Process / Task

Walkthrough

- Can you walk me through this process step by step, as if I'm doing it for the first time?
- What has to be true or in place *before* this process starts (prerequisites, access, tools)?
- What does "done" look like? How does the user know the task succeeded?

- Are there steps that are easy to get wrong or skip by mistake?
- Are there steps that vary depending on configuration, environment, or version?
- Is there a required order of operations, or can some steps happen in parallel?

4. Terminology and Precision

- Are there terms, abbreviations, or internal jargon I should define for readers?
- Are there terms your team uses that differ from what's in the UI, code, or vendor documentation?

- Is there a naming convention I need to follow exactly (field names, button labels, error codes)?
- Are there terms that are commonly confused or misused, even internally?

5. Edge Cases, Warnings, and Failure Points

- What are the most common mistakes new users/operators make?
- What has caused an incident, outage, safety issue, or support escalation in the past?

- Are there conditions where this process should *not* be performed, or should stop partway through?
- What's the worst-case outcome of doing this step incorrectly?
- Are there known bugs, limitations, or "it looks broken but it's not" behaviors to flag?

6. Safety, Compliance, and Approval Requirements

- Are there required PPE, certifications, or authorizations to perform this task?

- Are there regulatory, legal, or internal compliance requirements that affect how this must be documented?
- Does this process require sign-off, change approval, or a permit before it can be performed?
- Are there version-specific or region-specific requirements I need to account for?

7. Troubleshooting and Support

- What are the most frequent issues reported for this system/process?
- What's the standard first step when something goes wrong?

- When should a user stop and escalate rather than continue troubleshooting?
- Is there a known-issues list, changelog, or support ticket history worth reviewing?

8. Review and Validation

- Who needs to review the draft for technical accuracy before publication?
- Is there a test environment where I can validate steps myself before writing them?
- How should updates be handled going forward – who owns this content after I hand it off?

- Is there a review/revision cycle or documentation standard I should follow (templates, style guide, doc numbering)?
-

Interviewer Notes

(Use this space during or after the interview to capture direct quotes, clarifications needed, open questions, and action items.)

Open Question / Follow-Up	Owner	Status

How to Use This Template

1. Send relevant sections to the SME in advance if the interview is scheduled – it improves answer quality and saves time.
2. Record the session (with permission) in addition to taking notes; SMEs often mention critical edge cases informally, off the main question.
3. Confirm your draft against the SME's actual words before publishing – paraphrased technical detail is a common source of documentation errors.
4. File this questionnaire (with answers) alongside the published documentation as a

source-of-truth reference for
future updates.